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When regulars walked into New Delhi's Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium late last month, they would have noticed a striking change. The dull, patchy orange track that had served since the 2010 Commonwealth Games has been replaced by a gleaming, two-toned Mondotrack in shades of blue. The new surface, inaugurated on August 27, is part of a larger refurbishment ahead of the World Para Athletics Championships beginning



Final touches: Workers prepare the surface under a temporary scaffolding at JLN Stadium in Delhi as part of the ongoing arrangements for the Para World Athletics Championships, set to be hosted in India for the first time.

SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

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The lanes of the track alternate between dark and light blue, a detail that is not just cosmetic. "The most important part of any athletics stadium is the surface because it directly affects performance. Every Olympic and Paralympic Games takes place on a Mondotrack. It can improve performance by around 10 per cent. That's why we recommended it to the Sports Ministry. Even though it was expensive — the track cost about Rs.50 crore as part of the Rs. 80 crore stadium refurbishment — they agreed," says Satyapal Singh, chief coach of the Indian Para Athletics team and director of Para Athletics World Championships. "We've never had one in India before, and now we will have two: one in the main stadium and another in the practice area."

The alternating hues serve a practical purpose too. "It looks distinctive to spectators in the stadium or on television, but it's also very helpful for partially visually impaired athletes. It makes it easier for them to identify their lanes," Singh explains.

This emphasis on accessibility runs through the JLN Stadium

makeover. Built originally for the 1982 Asian Games, the venue has been reconfigured with para-athletes in mind: throwing and jumping areas modified, seating upgraded, ramps installed, lifts widened, and toilets redesigned. "The goal is to make the complex not just accessible to differently abled athletes but 'para-friendly,'" says Devendra Jhajharia, president of the Paralympic Committee of India (PCI).

"I've been training athletes at JLN Stadium for 20 years. The change has been dramatic," says Singh. **The jumping pits, for instance, have been widened from 3 to 3.5 metres to meet para-athlete requirements.** Throwing circles have been fitted with anchor points for seated competitors. "Zero labelling has been done on the track so that any wheelchair athlete or visually impaired athlete doesn't face problems," Singh adds.

Accessibility begins even before athletes reach the stadium. With around 350 wheelchair competitors expected, including 200 who use wheelchairs daily, PCI officials had to secure hotel rooms that were genuinely accessible. "That means level floors, support handles, and extra-wide bathrooms. There aren't